🚴 TOUR OF THEKKADY 2027

COMPLETE PREPARATION GUIDE

26-Week Training Plan + Vegetarian Diet Plan

Kottayam → Thekkady | 160 km | 3,000 m+ Elevation | 14-Hour Tour Window

EVENT AT A GLANCE

Route: Kottayam – Ettumanoor – Pala – Neeloor – Muttom – Kulamavu Dam – Idukki Dam – Kattappana – Puliyanmala – Anakkara – Thekkady

Your Category: Men-Masters — 160 km Endurance Tour | Cutoff: 14 hours | Flag-off: ~5:00–5:30 AM

Key Challenge: Sustained climbing from Muttom onwards; Calvary Mount (8 km gruelling ascent); Idukki–Kattappana highlands

PART 1: 26-WEEK TRAINING PLAN

📋 PLANNING FRAMEWORK

You have ~26 weeks before the next edition (typically held in February/March). This plan is divided into 4 phases. Your 5–6 hours/week indoor availability is well-utilised across weekday trainer sessions, with weekends reserved for outdoor rides. Your biggest training gap is climbing technique — this plan specifically addresses that.

PHASE 1 — BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1–6)

Goal: Build aerobic engine, cadence efficiency, and establish training habit. Indoor hours: 4–4.5 hrs/week.

Weekday Indoor Sessions (3 days)

- **Session A — Easy Aerobic Spin (60 min):** Maintain Zone 2 (60–70% max HR). Cadence: 80–90 rpm. This builds fat-burning capacity crucial for a 14-hr ride.
- **Session B — Cadence Drills (60 min):** 10 min warm-up → 5×5 min at 95–100 rpm with 5 min easy recovery → 10 min cool down. Improves pedalling efficiency for steep terrain.
- **Session C — Hill Simulation Intervals (75 min):** Increase trainer resistance. 3×10 min seated climbing at 70–75 rpm, Zone 3–4. Rest 5 min between sets. This is your earliest hill prep.

Weekend Outdoor Ride (1 day)

- Saturday or Sunday: 60–80 km on rolling terrain. Maintain conversational pace. Carry banana + dates as on-bike fuel. Practice hydration habits.
- Explore any local hilly road and include at least one 3–5 km moderate climb each weekend.

> ⚠ **KEY PHASE 1 FOCUS**
> *Do NOT try to go hard in Phase 1. The foundation of your success at Tour of Thekkady is built in these quiet weeks. Consistency over intensity. A 57-year-old athlete's recovery is gold — protect it.*

PHASE 2 — CLIMB-SPECIFIC TRAINING (Weeks 7–14)

Goal: Develop climbing strength, sustained power over long grades, and muscular endurance. Indoor hours: 5–5.5 hrs/week.

Indoor Trainer Workouts

- **Seated Climb Efforts (75 min):** 20 min warm-up → 3×12 min seated at 65–75 rpm @ Zone 3–4, resistance cranked high → 15 min cool-down. Simulates Thekkady's long sustained climbs.
- **Sweet-Spot Intervals (80 min):** 10 min warm-up → 3×15 min at 88–93% of FTP (sweet spot), 5 min recovery → 10 min cool-down. Best bang for your training buck.
- **VO2 Max Hill Reps (90 min):** 20 min warm-up → 4×5 min maximum effort on high resistance (Zone 5) → full 5 min recovery between → 20 min easy cool-down. Builds peak climbing power.

Outdoor Rides

- Target rides with 800–1200 m of cumulative elevation. Seek out roads with 5–8% gradient stretches if available near you.
- Practice standing vs. seated climbing. Alternate every 30 seconds on climbs. This builds both strength and endurance simultaneously.
- Try to include one 100+ km outdoor ride by Week 12, with 1000 m+ elevation.

> **CLIMBING TECHNIQUE NOTE**
> *For Thekkady's 8 km Calvary Mount climb: stay in the saddle as much as possible to conserve energy. Use your gravel bike's lowest gear and spin at 60–70 rpm rather than grinding at 50 rpm. Practice this technique from Week 7 itself on your trainer.*

PHASE 3 — EVENT SPECIFIC (Weeks 15–22)

Goal: Build event-specific endurance, back-to-back effort tolerance, and mental readiness. Indoor hours: 5.5–6 hrs/week.

Indoor Trainer Workouts

- **Tempo Climb Simulation (90 min):** 15 min warm-up → 2×20 min sustained tempo at Zone 3 on high resistance, 10 min easy → 15 min cool-down. Replicates prolonged Thekkady climbs.

- **Sweet-Spot Blocks (90 min):** 10 min warm-up → 4×15 min at sweet-spot zone, 5 min recovery → 10 min cool-down.
- **Recovery + Threshold Burst (60 min):** 20 min Zone 2 easy → 3×3 min threshold burst (Zone 4–5) → 25 min Zone 2 finish. Trains your body to recover during descents and re-attack on next climb.

Outdoor Long Rides (Critical Phase)

- **Week 16:** 110 km with 1500 m+ elevation — pace yourself at 65% effort for first 70 km.
- **Week 18:** 130 km, aim for 2000 m elevation if terrain allows. Practise fuelling every 40 km.
- **Week 20:** 150 km target, maximum elevation possible. This is your peak training ride — treat it like a race rehearsal. Start at 5:30 AM. Carry all your own nutrition.
- **Week 22:** 120 km, moderate effort. Begin dialling back for taper.

PHASE 4 — TAPER (Weeks 23–26)

Goal: Arrive at the start line fresh, sharp, and confident. Volume drops 40–50%; intensity maintained.

- **Weeks 23–24:** Reduce outdoor ride distance to 60–70 km. Keep 2 indoor sessions at moderate effort.
- **Weeks 25–26:** Mostly easy rides. One 50 km outdoor spin. Focus on sleep, hydration, and gut-testing your race-day nutrition.
- **Final week:** No hard rides after Wednesday. Rest Thursday & Friday. Light 30-min spin on Friday to open legs.

> **TAPER ANXIETY IS REAL**
>
> *You will feel sluggish and slow during the taper. That is normal. Trust the process — your muscles are storing glycogen and repairing. Do NOT add extra rides out of anxiety.*

WEEKLY TRAINING OVERVIEW TABLE

Use this at-a-glance guide to structure each week. Adjust based on how you feel — listening to your body is especially important at 57.

Phase	Mon	Tue	Wed/Thu	Sat	Sun
Phase 1 (Weeks 1–6) Base Building	Rest / Stretching	Trainer: 60 min Z2 easy spin	Trainer: 60 min Cadence drills 85–95 rpm	Trainer: 75 min hill simulation intervals	Outdoor: 60–80 km rolling terrain
Phase 2 (Weeks 7–14) Climb Specific	Rest / Foam roll	Trainer: 75 min seated climb efforts @ Z3–Z4	Trainer: 80 min 3×12 min sweet-spot intervals	Trainer: 90 min VO2 hill reps 4×5 min Z5	Outdoor: 80–110 km with 1000m+ elevation
Phase 3 (Weeks 15–	Rest	Trainer: 90 min sustained	Trainer: 90 min 4×15 min	Trainer: 60 min recovery + 20	Outdoor: 120–150 km, max

Phase	Mon	Tue	Wed/Thu	Sat	Sun
22) Event Specific		tempo Z3 climb sim	sweet-spot blocks	min threshold burst	elevation simulation
Phase 4 (Weeks 23–26) Taper	Rest	Trainer: 45 min easy with 3×5 min race pace efforts	Trainer: 60 min easy Z2 + 5 min openers	Rest / walk	Outdoor: 60 km easy with 2–3 short climbs

INDOOR TRAINER SETUP — MAKING THE MOST OF YOUR HYDRAULIC TRAINER

- **Fan:** Always use a strong fan. You lose up to 3x more heat on a trainer vs. outdoors. Overheating tanks performance.
- **Zone 2 reference:** At 57 years, estimate max HR as 163 bpm. Zone 2 = 98–114 bpm. Zone 3 = 114–130 bpm. Zone 4 = 130–147 bpm.
- **Music/Podcasts:** Use during Zone 2 rides only. For interval sessions, use a structured timer or cycling app.
- **Hydration:** Drink 500–600 ml/hour minimum on trainer. Add a pinch of sendha namak (rock salt) + lemon + jaggery to water.
- **Saddle time:** Build up gradually. If you develop saddle soreness, use chamois cream and get your saddle height professionally checked.

GEAR & BIKE NOTES — KONA AL 700 GRAVEL BIKE

- Your gravel bike is excellent for Thekkady's mixed terrain — rubber estates, forest patches, and tarmac climbs.
- **Gearing:** Check your lowest gear ratio. For 3000 m climbing, you need a compact crankset (50/34 or 46/30) paired with at least 34T cassette. If not already fitted, upgrade before the event.
- **Tyres:** Your road tyres are fine for this course. Ensure 28–32 mm width if possible for comfort on 160 km. Carry 2 tubes, a mini pump, and a multitool.
- **Bar tape:** Re-wrap fresh tape 2 weeks before the event. Your hands will thank you over 14 hours.
- **Lights:** A powerful rear light is mandatory. A front light is advisable for the early 5:30 AM start in Kerala's misty hills.

PART 2: VEGETARIAN DIET PLAN (INDIA-SPECIFIC)

This diet is calibrated for a 57-year-old, 81 kg, pure vegetarian endurance cyclist training for a 160 km event with 3000 m elevation. Your estimated daily caloric need on training days is 2600–2900 kcal; on rest days, 2000–2200 kcal. **Rajma, Chickpeas, Channa, Chole, and all Peanut/Groundnut products have been removed from this plan** due to dietary restrictions and replaced with equally nutritious alternatives.

> ✅ **YOUR RAGI ADVANTAGE**
>
> *Your daily Ragi (finger millet) porridge for breakfast is one of the best choices you could make as an endurance cyclist. Ragi is rich in calcium (essential for bone density at 57), iron, B-vitamins, and complex carbohydrates for sustained energy. Never skip it — it is your performance anchor.*

YOUR MACRONUTRIENT TARGETS

Nutrient	Rest Days	Training Days	Long Ride Days
Carbohydrates (main fuel)	5–6 g/kg body weight	6–7 g/kg body weight	7–9 g/kg body weight
Protein (recovery & muscle)	1.4–1.6 g/kg body weight	1.6–1.8 g/kg body weight	1.6–1.8 g/kg body weight
Fats (sustained energy)	0.8–1 g/kg body weight	0.8–1 g/kg body weight	1–1.2 g/kg body weight
Total approx. calories	~2000–2200 kcal	~2600–2800 kcal	~2800–3200 kcal

MEAL PLAN — FULL DAY BREAKDOWN

All food options are vegetarian (no eggs), Indian, and practically available. Rajma, Chickpeas, Channa, and Chole have been replaced with high-protein alternatives — Lobia (black-eyed peas), Moth beans (Matki), Val dal (field beans), and Urad dal.

Meal	Pre-Training Days	Long Ride Days	Recovery Days	Race Day	Timing
Pre-Dawn / Early Morning	Ragi porridge (base meal)	Ragi porridge + handful soaked raisins + 2 dates	Ragi porridge as usual	Ragi porridge + 2 dates + jaggery + banana	5:00–5:30 AM
Mid-Morning Snack	1 banana + 10 soaked almonds	1 banana + 15g almond butter on 1 roti	Handful walnuts + apple	On bike: Banana + dates every 40 km	9:00–10:00 AM

Meal	Pre-Training Days	Long Ride Days	Recovery Days	Race Day	Timing
Lunch	2 roti + moong dal + sabzi + salad + 1 cup curd	Large plate rice + lobia (black-eyed peas) or moth beans (matki) + 2 sabzi + curd	2 roti + moong dal + sabzi + curd	Aid station: Coconut water + banana + poha/upma if available	12:00–1:00 PM
Evening Snack	Roasted chana dal (split) + murmura OR makhana	Idli + coconut chutney OR poha with roasted sunflower seeds	Makhana + coconut water	On bike: Jaggery + sesame ladoo + dates	3:00–4:00 PM
Dinner	2 roti + paneer/tofu sabzi + sabzi + val dal (field beans) soup	Rice + urad dal makhani (black lentil) or moth beans curry + 2 sabzi + raita	Khichdi (rice + moong dal) + curd + 1 sabzi	Post-event: Bananas + coconut water + warm dal rice	7:00–8:00 PM
Post-Ride Recovery	Banana + 200 ml warm milk with turmeric + jaggery	Coconut water (immediate) + 30 min later: banana smoothie with milk + 1 tbsp almond butter or tahini (sesame paste)	Warm turmeric milk + 1 banana	Coconut water + banana immediately after finish	Within 30 min of ride

ON-BIKE FUELLING STRATEGY — RACE DAY

This is arguably the most critical skill for a 160 km / 14-hour ride. Most DNFs (Did Not Finish) in endurance events are nutrition failures, not fitness failures.

The 40 km Fuel Rule

- Eat something every 40 km — even if you don't feel hungry. Your gut is working, sweating, and cycling all at once. Hunger arrives too late.
- **0–40 km:** 1–2 dates + 200 ml water/electrolyte solution
- **40–80 km:** 1 banana + 200 ml coconut water (at aid station if available)
- **80–120 km:** 1 jaggery-sesame ladoo + 1 banana + 400 ml water
- **120–160 km:** 2 dates + remaining homemade rice cake + 400 ml coconut water or electrolyte

Homemade Race Nutrition (Better than Gels)

- **Jaggery-Sesame Ladoos:** Roast sesame seeds + jaggery + a pinch of dry ginger. Roll into lemon-sized balls. Pack 6–8 in a jersey pocket. Each provides ~80 kcal of fast + sustained energy.
- **Date-Almond Butter Wrap:** Half a chapati, smeared with almond butter + 2 chopped dates. Wrap tight. Provides 200 kcal of complex carbs + protein. (Almond butter is peanut-free and equally energy-dense.)

- **Rice Cakes:** Cooked rice (slightly sticky) + a pinch of rock salt + a pinch of jeera. Press into flat cakes. Wrap in foil. Easy on the stomach at 100+ km.
- **Electrolyte Water (DIY):** 500 ml water + 1/4 tsp rock salt (sendha namak) + juice of half a lemon + 1 tsp jaggery powder. Far superior to plain water in preventing cramps on 3000 m climbs.

⚡ CRITICAL: CLIMBING & CRAMPING

The Idukki–Kattappana stretch is notorious for cramps among under-fuelled riders. Start your electrolyte sipping from the 60 km mark onwards (before Kulamavu Dam). Magnesium is your friend — include it in your diet from Phase 2 onwards: pumpkin seeds, dark chocolate (jaggery-based), and dark leafy vegetables.

KEY FOODS TO INCLUDE IN YOUR DAILY DIET

🔄 DIETARY RESTRICTIONS APPLIED

The following items have been REMOVED from this plan:

• Rajma (kidney beans), Chickpeas, Channa, Chole — dietary restriction
• Peanuts, Peanut butter, Groundnut oil — allergy

Replaced with: Lobia, Moth beans (Matki), Val dal, Urad dal for legumes; Almond butter, Tahini (sesame paste), Sunflower seeds, Coconut oil for peanut alternatives. All substitutes are nutritionally comparable or superior and safe for consumption.

Carbohydrate Sources (Your Main Fuel)

- Ragi (finger millet) — breakfast staple: continue and increase portion on training days
- Brown rice / hand-pounded rice — prefer over white rice
- Jowar (sorghum) and Bajra (pearl millet) rotis — excellent complex carbs
- Sweet potato (shakarkandi) — ideal pre-ride evening meal
- Oats — overnight oats with jaggery and banana on long-ride mornings
- Banana — the cyclist's best friend. 1–2 per day minimum during training
- Dates (Khajoor) — quick energy, carry always on rides

Protein Sources (Pure Vegetarian — Rajma/Chickpeas/Channa/Chole/Peanuts EXCLUDED)

- Moong dal, masoor dal, toor dal, chana dal (split) — rotate daily for amino acid variety
- **Lobia (black-eyed peas):** ~24g protein per 100g dry. Ideal post-long-ride dinner. Easier to digest than kidney beans. Cook in a simple tomato-onion curry.
- **Moth beans / Matki:** ~23g protein per 100g dry. Excellent sprouted or as a dry sabzi. Widely used in Maharashtra and South India. Sprout overnight for maximum nutrition.
- **Val dal / Field beans (Vaal):** ~20–22g protein per 100g dry. Popular in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. Use in dal or sambhar-style preparations.
- **Urad dal (whole black lentil / Kali dal):** ~24g protein per 100g dry. Slow-cooked as dal makhani style (without cream). Rich in B-vitamins and iron. Excellent overnight recovery food.
- **Paneer (cottage cheese):** 100–150g on training days. Rich in casein for overnight recovery.

- **Tofu:** Excellent protein + phytoestrogens good for joint health at 57.
- **Almond butter (natural, no added sugar):** 1–2 tbsp/day. Excellent peanut-free fat + protein combo. Rich in vitamin E and magnesium — both critical for endurance athletes.
- **Sattu (roasted gram flour):** 2 tbsp in cold water = instant recovery drink post-trainer session.
- **Milk (full fat):** 200–300 ml at night with turmeric and jaggery (haldi doodh). Aids sleep and recovery.

Substitution Summary: Removed vs Replacement Foods

All values are approximate protein content per 100g of dry/uncooked legume.

REMOVED Food	Reason	REPLACEMENT
Rajma (kidney beans)	Dietary restriction	Lobia (black-eyed peas) — ~24g protein ✅
Chickpeas / Channa / Chole	Dietary restriction	Moth beans (Matki) — ~23g protein ✅
(Dinner dal variety)	—	Urad dal / Val dal — ~21–24g protein ✅
Peanut butter / Peanuts	Peanut allergy	Almond butter / Tahini — comparable fat + protein ✅
Groundnut / Peanut oil	Peanut allergy	Cold-pressed coconut oil or sesame oil ✅
Poha with peanuts	Peanut allergy	Poha with roasted sunflower seeds or pumpkin seeds ✅

Fat Sources (Sustained Energy & Joint Health)

- Almonds (badam): 15–20 soaked almonds every morning — vitamin E, healthy fats
- Walnuts (akhrot): 4–6 daily — omega-3, excellent for heart and joint inflammation
- Flaxseeds (alsi): 1 tsp ground into your ragi porridge — omega-3, fibre, anti-inflammatory
- Sesame seeds (til): In ladoos and in sabzi — calcium + healthy fats
- Coconut (fresh grated or coconut milk): Kerala is your home ground! Fresh coconut chutney, coconut in sabzi, coconut water for hydration
- Cold-pressed coconut oil or cold-pressed sesame oil — use for cooking over refined vegetable oil (groundnut/peanut oil avoided due to allergy)

Micronutrients — Critical for a 57-Year-Old Endurance Athlete

- **Calcium:** Ragi, sesame seeds, almonds, milk, paneer — vital for bone density during climbing impacts
- **Iron:** Spinach (palak), amaranth (rajgira), dates, dark chocolate (jaggery-sweetened) — prevents fatigue
- **Vitamin D:** 20–30 minutes of morning sun exposure before your trainer ride. No food substitute
- **Magnesium:** Pumpkin seeds (kaddu ke beej), dark chocolate, banana, spinach — prevents cramps on climbs
- **Potassium:** Banana, coconut water, sweet potato — electrolyte balance during long rides

- **B12:** Consider a doctor-prescribed supplement — plant-only diets are often B12 deficient. B12 deficiency causes fatigue and weakness in endurance sport

HYDRATION PROTOCOL

- **Daily:** Minimum 3.5–4 litres of water. Increase to 5+ litres on long ride days.
- **Morning:** 2–3 glasses warm water with lemon on waking (no sugar — you already avoid this correctly).
- **Coconut water:** 200–400 ml fresh coconut water on training days as afternoon electrolyte.
- **Avoid:** Carbonated drinks, packaged juices, sports drinks with artificial colours/flavours.
- **Buttermilk (chaach):** Excellent recovery drink. 1 glass post-afternoon training. Add jeera + rock salt + fresh coriander.

FOODS TO AVOID OR MINIMISE

- Maida (refined flour) products — bread, biscuits, namkeen. No nutritional value for performance.
- Fried snacks (bajji, vada, chips) — heavy, slow digestion; disaster on a long ride.
- Packaged protein bars or powders — most contain artificial sweeteners or whey. Not needed if your whole-food diet is right.
- Heavy curries before a long ride — choose simple, well-cooked food the night before an outdoor ride.
- Excess fibre on ride morning — no high-fibre raw salad before a 150 km ride. Stick to ragi porridge.

🌿 PRE-EVENT MEAL (Night Before Tour of Thekkady)

Keep it simple and familiar. Rice + moong dal + a light sabzi + curd. A small banana 90 min before sleep. This is not the time to experiment. Your gut-training during the 26 weeks is what prepares you for this night.

PART 3: RACE DAY STRATEGY & FINAL TIPS

PACING STRATEGY FOR A 14-HOUR FINISH

- **Kottayam to Muttom (~55 km, rolling):** This is your warm-up. Hold back. Go at 65% effort. Many riders blow up here because of excitement at the start.
- **Muttom to Kulamavu Dam (~30 km, first serious climbs):** Shift down early. Spin. Don't race anyone. Stay aerobic.
- **Kulamavu to Kattappana (Calvary Mount included, ~40 km, hardest section):** This is where the race is won or lost. Eat at 80 km and 100 km. Ride at 70–75% maximum. Walk short sections if needed — no shame, smart riding.
- **Kattappana to Thekkady (~35 km, final stretch):** If you paced correctly, you have a reserve here. Pick it up slightly. The finish near Periyar Tiger Reserve gate is deeply rewarding.

FINAL PRE-EVENT CHECKLIST

- Book accommodation in Thekkady at least 8 weeks in advance — it fills up quickly
- Register on the official Tour of Thekkady website (registration typically opens January, closes February 12–15)
- Get your bike serviced 3 weeks before: derailleur, brakes, chain, tyres
- Pack a drop bag for Thekkady: fresh jersey, dry snacks, electrolyte sachets, pain balm
- Do a full gear test ride at Week 24 — wear exactly what you'll wear on event day
- Travel to Kottayam a day early. Rest, hydrate, sleep well
- Flag-off is typically 5:00–5:30 AM from Nagampadam, Kottayam — be there by 4:30 AM

🏁 **YOUR GOAL AT TOUR OF THEKKADY**

Finish strong within the 14-hour window. Enjoy the scenery, the cardamom estates, the Idukki Dam, and the forest stretch. You have 11 years of cycling in your legs and a healthy, disciplined lifestyle behind you. This event is your reward — and with this preparation, you will cross that finish line at Periyar with a smile.

Ride safe. Ride strong. See you at Thekkady!

— Tour of Thekkady 2027 Preparation Guide (Updated Diet Plan) —